Tired Zverev Says He 'Overachieved' by Reaching Shanghai Semifinal

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German tennis star Alexander Zverev reached the semifinals of the Shanghai Masters, but his tournament ended there. Afterward, he said he felt he had "**overachieved**" because he was so tired.

Zverev, who is ranked world number two, has had a busy schedule. He has had little chance to rest between the US Open, the Laver Cup, the Beijing Masters and Shanghai. He said he came into the event carrying a little bit of injury and **fatigue**.

"I feel like I've actually, in a way, maybe **overachieved** this week because of how much tennis I played," Zverev said.

In the semifinal, he played Davidovich Fokina, the tournament's 25th **seed**. Zverev won the first set. But his opponent hit an excellent backhand passing shot to break Zverev's serve and push the match to a deciding third set. Zverev fell behind 2-0 in that set and could not recover.

Zverev said he had felt "flat" since a tough fourth-round match against Alexander Bublik that went to a third-set **tie-break**. He did play very well in the quarterfinal, beating Alex de Minaur in **straight sets**.

"We're all human beings, even the best players in the world," he said.

The loss was a rare disappointment in a brilliant season. Zverev won the first **Grand Slam** title of his career at the French Open in June, then won a second at the US Open in September. He is also guaranteed to finish the year as world number one, and he will be the first German man to do so.

Davidovich Fokina reached his first ATP Masters 1000 final since 2022. He will face fellow Spaniard Rafael Jodar in the final on Sunday.

Word Treasure

overachieved -- Did better than expected.

fatigue -- A feeling of being very tired.

seed -- A player's ranking position in a tournament, used to plan who plays whom.

tie-break -- A special short game used to decide a set when the score is tied.

straight sets -- Winning a match without losing a single set.

Grand Slam -- One of tennis's four biggest tournaments, such as the French Open and US Open.

Background you need

Professional tennis players travel to tournaments around the world for most of the year, earning ranking points for their wins.

The four Grand Slam tournaments, including the French Open and the US Open, are the sport's biggest events.

Masters tournaments, like the one in Shanghai, are among the top events on the men's tour just below the Grand Slams.

A match is won by taking the most sets, and a close set can be decided by a tie-break.

Break it down

LEAD: Zverev reached the Shanghai Masters semifinals and said he overachieved
KEY EVENT: Lost the semifinal to 25th seed Davidovich Fokina in three sets
+- WHY: Fatigue and a little injury after a busy schedule
+- EARLIER: Beat Alex de Minaur in straight sets; tough match with Alexander Bublik
QUOTE: "We're all human beings, even the best players in the world"
SEASON: French Open and US Open titles; guaranteed year-end world number one
NEXT: Davidovich Fokina faces Rafael Jodar in Sunday's final

Why it matters

Zverev's comments show that even top athletes get tired and need rest, and that one loss does not erase a great season.

Test what you remember

1. What is Zverev's current world ranking?

- (A) Number two
- (B) Number 25
- (C) Number ten
- (D) Number one

2. Who beat Zverev in the semifinal?

- (A) Davidovich Fokina
- (B) Rafael Jodar
- (C) Alexander Bublik
- (D) Alex de Minaur

3. Which Grand Slam titles did Zverev win this season?

- (A) Only Wimbledon
- (B) Wimbledon and the Australian Open
- (C) The French Open and the US Open
- (D) The Laver Cup and Beijing

4. Why did Zverev say he overachieved?

- (A) Because he won the tournament
- (B) Because it was his first tournament
- (C) Because he had a long rest before
- (D) Because of how much tennis he had played and how tired he was

5. Whom did Zverev beat in straight sets in the quarterfinal?

- (A) Davidovich Fokina
- (B) Alex de Minaur
- (C) Rafael Jodar
- (D) Alexander Bublik

6. What will Zverev become by finishing the year as world number one?

- (A) The first German man to do so
- (B) The first player from Shanghai to do so
- (C) The youngest player ever to do so
- (D) The oldest champion in history

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: C 4: D 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Alexander Zverev: Says he overachieved because of his fatigue and had felt flat since his match against Alexander Bublik.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):